

The One Hundred and Eight Names of the Noble Avalokiteśvara

Āryāvalokiteśvarasya nāma aṣṭaśatakam · Toh 705 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སྐྱ་རས་གཟགིས་དབང་ཕྱག་མཆོན་བརྒྱ་མར་ཏུ་པ།

The One Hundred and Eight Names of the Noble Avalokiteśvara, known in Sanskrit as the Āryāvalokiteśvarasya nāma aṣṭaśatakam and in Tibetan as Phakpa Chenrezik Wangchuk gi Tsen Gyatsa Gyepa, is a devotional sūtra enumerating one hundred and eight names of the great bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara, the Sovereign Lord of Vision. Set at the celestial palace atop Potala Mountain — the mythic abode of Avalokiteśvara himself — the text opens with a vast assembly of gods, nāgas, and other beings gathered in reverence before the Blessed One, establishing the occasion for the recitation of these sacred names. As a collection of epithets honoring one of the most beloved figures in the Mahāyāna tradition, it belongs to the category of nāmasaṃgīti or name-praise literature. This text is Toh 705 in the Kangyur, and was translated into Tibetan by the scholar Ngok Loden Sherab together with a Kashmirian paṇḍita.

Translated by Ngok Loden Sherab and the Kashmirian paṇḍita.

In the language of India: Āryāvalokiteśvarasya nāma aṣṭaśatakam.

In the Tibetan language: The One Hundred and Eight Names of the Noble Avalokiteśvara, the Sovereign Lord of Vision.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling at the palace on the summit of the Potala Mountain, the abode of the noble Avalokiteśvara, the Sovereign Lord — a place scattered with various sweetly fragrant flowers, its color resembling the gold of the Jambu river, ablaze on all sides with an array of precious jewels. There, many tens of billions and hundreds of thousands of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, great serpents, humans, and non-humans rendered reverence to the Blessed One, honored him as their supreme teacher, paid him homage, and offered him devotion and respect. Surrounding him and standing in his presence, he taught them the Dharma — good at the beginning, good in the middle, good at the end, excellent in meaning, excellent in word, perfectly pure, perfectly cleansed, complete and unmixed, fully clear — teaching in its entirety and perfectly the holy life of complete purity alone.

Then Brahmā and the rest praised the great bodhisattva, the noble Avalokiteśvara, the Sovereign Lord:

"Hail, hail! Awakened One, Blessed One —
you have done what had to be done, you have accomplished the task.
You have set down the burden and attained your own aim.
The bond to continued existence is utterly exhausted.
Your mind is liberated through the authentic teaching,
supremely freed through wisdom.

Like the great nāga you are ever tranquil,
master of the mind and all things,
having attained the highest perfection.
The accumulation of gnosis is complete and whole.
You have crossed utterly beyond the wilderness of existence,
and strive diligently in benefiting others,
with a mind joined always to compassion,
deeply loving toward all living creatures.

Virtue is born of diligence and loving-kindness;
you are skilled in liberating boundless sentient beings.
You are born from the Sugata himself,
by the very word of the Sugata.
You are the sole friend of the three realms,
free of attachment, aversion, and delusion —
the three stains entirely abandoned.
You have perfected the three kinds of knowledge
and attained all six superknowledges.

Round as the nyagrodha tree,
adorned with the thirty-two marks of a great being,
and graced in every aspect of your body
with eighty minor marks of excellence.
Your complexion resembles the color of gold,
your body large and brilliantly luminous.
Like the nāga-kesara flower in its youth,
your hue slightly tinged with red.

Your crown is adorned with a ushnīsha,
wrapped around with many plaits of hair.
Upon your head dwells Amitābha;

rays of light stream forth in all directions,
blazing brilliantly for a fathom round,
filling space with renown like a golden mountain —
your splendor vast and magnificent.

Adorned with the crest of a sun rising over an eastern peak,
you are beautified across half your body
with a blazing precious jewel set in gold.
You are perfectly skilled in the grounds,
practicing the ten perfections,
your ethical discipline unimpaired and unwavering.

Like a lion with flowing mane,
your body is gentle and graceful.
In your gaze and your movement you resemble the finest stallion.
You are like a rightward-coiling conch,
your forehead like a full moon,
broad and wide in its proportions.
The space between the brows is full and unbroken.
Your eyes blaze like precious jewels.
Your nose is slightly raised in form.
The luster of your teeth surpasses all.
Your tongue covers a triple thousandfold world,
and your ear-passages are supremely deep.
Your neck, too, resembles a vase with a graceful throat.
Your shoulders are perfectly round.
The joints of your fingers are long;
your nails are soft and slightly reddish;
your fingers are webbed between.
On the palms of your hands and the soles of your feet
are wheels, adorning them with supreme beauty."

Your face is beautiful as the autumn lotus.
Your body's hue is soft, your flesh full and abundant.
Your voice is as deep as the melody of Brahmā,
pleasing and delightful to the mind.
Lovely to behold, your radiance brings joy.
Born from the lotus, you have the color of the lotus;
arisen everywhere from pure lotuses,

you are enthroned upon a seat of pure lotuses.
In your hands you hold the noble lotus.
You hold a water-vessel pouring from the crown,
and you carry the skin of a black antelope.
You wield a staff and hold a rosary of beads.
You purify all through auspicious signs.
You speak gently, proclaiming truth from before,
and let fall a supreme rain of ambrosia.
Like a wish-fulfilling jewel of great price,
you bring joy to every sentient being.
Like a tree of goodly appearance,
you become nourishment for all sentient beings.
You are the emanation of all buddhas,
possessing the bearing and form of the Sugata.
You hold the sacred relics of the Sugata.
Each and every hair of your body
becomes a lord and protector of all sentient beings.
You create merit and perform virtue;
you are without haste and wholly certain,
possessed of renowned and tireless diligence.
You cross over entirely beyond all of saṃsāra.
Enthroned as regent of the sacred Dharma,
you turn the wish-fulfilling wheel in bliss.
With the noose of Amoghapāśa you draw out afflictions.
The noble Hayagrīva vanquishes the four māras.
Krodhāsura of the blue throat dispels all harm.
You liberate from the fear of the throne of the crocodile.
The goddess Tārā follows in your train.
The wrathful Bhṛkuṭī acts at your command.
The victorious one is endowed with proper conduct;
endowed with great power and mindfulness,
endowed with qualities and with loving-kindness,
endowed with wisdom and with splendor,
endowed with ethical discipline and with purpose.
You are the knower of all meanings,
the one who cuts through every doubt,
the one who proclaims all phenomena,

the Teacher of the entire world.
Your face is fair as a fish-bearing moon.
Your lower body is adorned with every jewel.
You stand like a golden pillar of offering,
your brilliance surpassing that of a thousand suns.
Praised and worshipped by Brahmā and all the rest,
I pay homage to the protector of the world.

Whoever praises the noble Avalokiteśvara with these one hundred and eight names — the five sins of immediate retribution in their karmic obscurations shall be completely purified. They shall gain entry into all maṇḍalas. All mantras shall be accomplished. For a thousand aeons they shall not be born in the lower realms. They shall not fall into the Avīci hell. Whoever, having turned toward the Dharma, reads this, causes others to read it, or recites it aloud — their body shall be free from all illness, including leprosy, skin disease, lung disease, respiratory discomfort, and so forth. In all births, in every rebirth, they shall remember their past lives. They shall be like the children of the gods. Even at the time of death, they shall be born in the world-realm of Sukhāvatī. Wherever they are born and wherever they dwell, they shall never be separated from the noble Avalokiteśvara. If one recites this constantly, one's mind shall become joyful, one shall become courageous, one's voice shall become melodious, one shall become fortunate, one shall become learned in all fields of knowledge, and one's words shall become pure.

Through praising with this praise, it becomes equal to having made offerings to as many buddhas, blessed ones, as there are grains of sand in sixty-two Ganges rivers; and since the karmic maturation is alike, there is no difference whatsoever.

This concludes The Noble Casket of Precious Relics of All the Victors, the one hundred and eight names of the noble Avalokiteśvara.

Translator's Notes

- The opening lines give the text's colophon and title. The translation identifies the Tibetan translators: Ngok Loden Sherab (Rngog Blo Idan shes rab, 1059–1109) and a Kashmiri paṇḍita whose name is given in the Tibetan as Klog-skyā Shes-rab-brtsegs. The Sanskrit title *Āryāvalokiteśvarasya nāma aṣṭaśatakaṃ* means "The One Hundred and Eight Names of the Noble Avalokiteśvara," and this Sanskrit title is preserved as it appears in the text.

The term rendered "rākṣasas" (srin po) refers to a class of powerful demonic or spirit beings in Indian cosmology.

The term rendered "garuḍas" (nam mkha' lding) literally means "sky-soarer" and refers to the great mythical bird-beings of Indian tradition.

The phrase "great serpents" (lto 'phye chen po) refers to great serpentine beings, often identified with powerful nāga-like creatures distinct from the nāgas listed separately.

The "three kinds of knowledge" (rig pa gsum) refers classically to the three higher knowledges: recollection of past lives, knowledge of the death and rebirth of beings, and knowledge of the exhaustion of the outflows.

The "six superknowledges" (mngon par shes pa drug) are the six abhijñās: supernatural powers of movement, clairvoyance, clairaudience, knowledge of others' minds, recollection of past lives, and knowledge of the exhaustion of the outflows.

The "nyagrodha tree" (nya gro dha, Skt. nyagrodha) is the Indian banyan fig, *Ficus benghalensis*, noted for its round, spreading form — a standard simile in the body-mark literature for the proportionate, rounded build of a great being.

- The figure "Krodhāsura of the blue throat" renders Krodha mgrin sngon, a wrathful deity whose blue throat echoes Śiva's epithet Nīlakaṇṭha; the text presents this as a separate figure in Avalokiteśvara's retinue rather than Śiva himself, so no parenthetical gloss was inserted into the body, though listeners familiar with Śaiva iconography will recognize the allusion.

The term rendered "fish-bearing moon" follows the Tibetan nya ba, literally "having fish," a standard epithet of the full moon in Tibetan poetic convention, referring to the markings seen on the lunar disc.

"Amoghapāśa" is the Sanskrit name of the noose-bearing form of Avalokiteśvara implied by the Tibetan don yod zhags pa; inserting the Sanskrit here best preserves the doctrinal specificity for listeners familiar with this tantric form.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.